

How's your head today?

THERE is a well-established rule that the appearance of human beings never gets better, only stranger. I thought we had reached the nadir around 1970 right in the pride of the Beatles era.

How wrong we were. There is no limit to human ingenuity — we haven't reached the bottom even yet, I tell you. Just wait for 1990.

Two nights ago I nicked down to the bank to work the automatic teller. There standing in front of the money machine were two remarkable creatures dressed like nomadic Mongolian tribesmen. Their jogging shoes were the give-away.

He was a brilliant example of a modern Apache, a flaring orange strip of hair standing vertically, a noble spur down the centre of his scalp.

She was totally bald, except, now here's the fascinating part... she had a long fishing line of hair trailing down from just above each ear, a ring through her nose and even the chandelier at the West Point Casino couldn't beat her right ear which had a large ring through the main lobe, then a dozen more all the way up the ear.

The best time to see human beings in their full glory is on Saturday mornings. For some reason this is parade time and they seem to surface about 11 am.

Last Saturday morning I saw mother and daughter with matching vermilion tufts and a male-female duo with wonderful powerful aerial structures 30 centimetres high, a triumph of the power of super glue.

Five years ago we were told that punk was the protest of the young, the contempt they were showing for modern society. Shave your head, grow a purple tuft and show what you think of Hawke-Peacock-Sinclair-Wras-Cain and Joh all rolled into one.

By KEITH DUNSTAN

Untrue. These people aren't protesting. They just think Boy George is perfection in human beauty and they want to look the same.

It is rewarding to meet some of our more daring hair stylists. The first thing you learn is that they dress differently now. Back in the old days it was important to have the mystique of Dr Kildare, all in antiseptic white as if you were about to do a brain transplant.

It was interesting to meet Luke. Luke did the hair-dos for the stars in Mad Max.

Luke was wearing a leather jacket covered in metal studs, a yellow shirt, a black tie, tartan pants, red shoes. You would think that his striped socks would be subdued by the rest of his gear, but this wasn't true.

Luke himself had a fine balloon of hair, fiercely scrunched. His apprentice Sean had his head shaved apache style. He had a long white bobtail down the back of his head and several lesser, more string-like bobtails on either side.

Luke explained bobtails usually were synthetic and they were woven into the hair. You could buy them in 21 different colours.

"But how do you sleep with all that lot?"

"It's difficult," said Sean. "You tend to wake up with your bobtails tangled."

Naturally one wondered about the gorgeous colours Hilton Bell does for the TV stars. His salon sports several huge pictures of an extraordinary young lady. You could imagine the reaction upon saying: "Mother, meet my new girl friend."

In one picture she is totally bald. In the other she is riding a huge Harley Davidson motor bike, the sides of her head are shaved, she has eyebrows past her ears and the top hair is cropped short.

Hilton Bell had a beard and a T-shirt with glaring eyes on the stomach. He said the brilliant colours you saw on the girls were "crazy colours", most of which would wash out and fade in about four weeks.

He and Luke are kindly men. They claim that before you do this sort of thing, you must have the courage and personality to carry it off.

"If I see them trembling a bit I talk them out of it," said Hilton.

Mr Bell calls himself a "designer in hair" and his price list was intriguing... Moonshining: \$12-\$22; Marbelizing: \$36-\$48; Tortoiseshelling: \$36-\$48 and Scrunching: \$12.

Scrunching, one learned, is like kneading dough. At the last Academy Awards Diane Keaton and Jacqueline Bisset were thoroughly scrunched.

Hilton Bell said it was invented by a friend of his in London, more or less by accident. He was drying a lady's hair with his hands, taking great handfuls of it as he used the blower. She was in a desperate hurry so he was working harder and harder. Something started to happen, the hair seemed to explode.

"Hang on, hey! That's not bad."

So scrunching was born.

What will happen next? Hilton Bell believes people will start to put objects into their hair. The earring craze will ascend about the scalp.

Luke thinks they will go for fascinating geometric patterns.

After talking to these people for a time you start to feel miserably dull and self-conscious about your 1948 late-Sullivan's hairdo.

I had several wonderful offers to have my hair done. I said: "Yes... well... wait a minute. I'll have to purchase my Harley first."



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